

Chapter 143-1

Greedy—what a terrifying word.

She had originally thought herself free of desires and wants, able to live even without love.

Yet now she was pressing closer step by step, wanting her love.

Even less love wouldn't do.

Xu Qingzhu's voice was very low, breathily murmuring an entire sentence—ambiguous and tender.

But Liang Shi was still lost in their earlier deep kiss, her consciousness hazy. She couldn't pull herself out for the moment, nor did she hear what Xu Qingzhu said.

By the time she thought to ask, Xu Qingzhu had already stopped speaking and was instead nibbling on her earlobe.

Cool fingertips wreaked havoc on Liang Shi's glands. The rich tea fragrance of Baihao Yinzen¹ spread throughout the car. Liang Shi wrapped her arm around her waist and negotiated in a low voice: "Stop messing around. Tonight."

"We agreed there'd be no messing around tonight." Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi: "..."

These past few days, they seemed to have been breaking their agreements in perfect unspoken accord.

Clearly thinking they absolutely wouldn't do it again, yet always breaking that resolve time after time.

It was indeed quite pleasurable.

Liang Shi asked her: "So you're not going to work anymore?"

"I can skip it." Xu Qingzhu answered, her voice hoarse.

"We're still outside." Liang Shi said, then paused: "Xu Qingzhu, is your heat period not over yet?"

These words seemed to have touched some sensitive nerve in Xu Qingzhu. As if a spring had been pressed on her body, she immediately sat up and moved to the car seat.

Not looking the slightest bit like someone lost in passion.

The atmosphere in the car instantly turned cold, the romantic feeling gone without a trace.

That scorching kiss from just moments ago seemed like it had all been Liang Shi's imagination.

"I..." Liang Shi pressed her lips together, asking somewhat at a loss: "Did I say something wrong?"

Xu Qingzhu straightened her slightly disheveled clothes, fished out the cup of milk tea from under the car seat, took a straw from the bag, and calmly poked it through.

Pop!

A very loud sound.

Xu Qingzhu took a sip of the milk tea. The tapioca pearls at the bottom were very sticky, and the taste was mediocre.

"No." Xu Qingzhu's expression was bland: "I just felt like drinking milk tea."

She seemed like a completely different person from the one who had just been sitting on Liang Shi's lap, passionately kissing her.

That kiss just now had been so scorching it had nearly melted Liang Shi. If not for a thread of rationality remaining, Liang Shi would definitely have done something reckless with her right there in the car.

But out of consideration for the things she still had to handle this afternoon, she had put on the brakes in time.

And now Xu Qingzhu had withdrawn so quickly. The way she sat with lowered eyes drinking milk tea didn't look at all like someone who had just experienced arousal. Yet when asked, she insisted she wasn't angry.

Liang Shi didn't know what to do and could only wait quietly.

The sound of Xu Qingzhu sipping her milk tea was very soft, but in the quiet car, it was clearly audible.

She could even hear the sound of her chewing the tapioca pearls distinctly, as well as the sound of her throat swallowing.

This was a form of torture.

After a while, Liang Shi asked her softly again: "Xu Qingzhu, did something troubling happen at work?"

Because she felt Xu Qingzhu was angry, Liang Shi didn't dare use those intimate terms of address. Even calling her "Xu Qingzhu" was done with great care.

Xu Qingzhu shook her head: "No, everything is going smoothly."

There were even plans to acquire a small company.

"Then..." Liang Shi couldn't think of what else might have made her angry. After a long pause, she still couldn't say anything.

Footnotes:

¹ **Baihao Yinzhen** (白毫銀針): Also known as "Silver Needle White Tea," this is one of the most prized and expensive Chinese white teas. It's made only from the unopened buds of the tea plant, which are covered in fine silvery-white hairs (白毫). The tea has a delicate, sweet flavor with subtle floral notes. In this ABO universe, it's Liang Shi's pheromone scent.

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Xu Qingzhu frowned as she drank half a cup of the not-so-tasty milk tea, calming her mood by chewing the sticky tapioca pearls.

It took her quite a while to settle her emotions enough to speak normally to Liang Shi.

She looked at Liang Shi: "Liang Shi, why are you good to me?"

Liang Shi was taken aback, as if she hadn't expected her to ask such a question.

But she answered almost without thinking: "You're my wife. If I'm not good to you, who would I be good to?"

An expected answer.

Xu Qingzhu's slender pale fingers gripped the milk tea cup. The PVC cup was nearly being crushed out of shape in her hands, making a slight sound accompanied by the liquid sloshing against the walls of the cup.

"What if your wife were someone else? Would you treat her just as well?" Xu Qingzhu asked in a flat tone.

Liang Shi was stunned.

She had never thought about this question.

Liking Xu Qingzhu seemed to have happened naturally.

And all along, while it appeared that she was the one actively approaching Xu Qingzhu, in reality it was Xu Qingzhu who had been constantly accommodating her.

Xu Qingzhu was very smart—smart enough to guess about another world, smart enough to guess that she had tasks she had to complete.

Yet she never asked about any of it.

Including her return.

All of Xu Qingzhu's curiosity could come to an abrupt halt in her silence.

Just like moments ago—she was clearly the one who initiated the teasing, the one who was aroused first, yet she was also the one who withdrew first.

She left Liang Shi unable to figure her out.

After a moment, Liang Shi said: "This question doesn't exist."

"You're my wife, so I'm good to you." Liang Shi said: "No one else will become my wife, so... it's only you."

At times like this, Liang Shi was ridiculously inarticulate. She didn't know how to organize her words to make Xu Qingzhu understand her feelings, nor did she know how to explain what she meant.

"But what if there were?" Xu Qingzhu said: "If you had met someone else, would you be like this too?"

Xu Qingzhu's eyes stared straight at her, making Liang Shi's face feel hot.

It was like the awkward feeling of being called on by a teacher during school and not being able to answer.

After a long while, Xu Qingzhu sighed. "Forget it."

She lowered her eyes and took a sip of milk tea. Just as Liang Shi was saying: "This question has no hypothetical..."

Xu Qingzhu leaned in and kissed her, transferring all the milk tea in her mouth over. The sweet taste spread between their lips and teeth.

Blocking all of Liang Shi's ill-timed answers.

This kiss from Xu Qingzhu was even more intense than before.

She used almost all her strength, her breathing much heavier than before, nearly running out of breath several times.

Liang Shi's back was pressed against the back seat of the car. Xu Qingzhu's legs were wrapped directly around her waist.

All the moisture on their lips was swallowed by the other.

...

Just from simple kissing, physiological tears were drawn from Xu Qingzhu, hanging delicately on her eyelashes. She looked so pitiful that it made one want to bully her some more.

It was also today that Liang Shi finally understood what it meant for a tongue to be able to tie a cherry stem in a knot, and she unlocked the correct way to do so.

Xu Qingzhu's tongue was far too nimble—like a fish swimming through water.

All of Liang Shi's rationality crumbled in an instant. She only wanted to be reckless together with her.

But they only went as far as kissing.

Though the hem of Xu Qingzhu's sweater had been pushed up a bit, revealing her beautiful stomach.

Xu Qingzhu was thin, but she didn't like working out, so her abdomen had no excess fat but also no abs.

A few days ago, the two of them had discussed this topic in bed. At the time, Xu Qingzhu had declared with conviction: "Someone said that as long as you're thin enough, you'll have abs. So once I get a bit thinner, I'll have them."

But Liang Shi had said: "Whether you have abs depends on your body fat percentage, so you need to exercise."

Xu Qingzhu covered her ears. "I'm not listening."

She had been quite childish then too.

The hooks of her bra only needed to be pushed back to come undone completely.

Liang Shi wasn't too wooden either—she knew how to do some simple teasing while kissing.

But that teasing seemed quite inexperienced compared to Xu Qingzhu's kiss, which was so scorching it could melt someone.

Xu Qingzhu only ended the kiss when she had nearly pushed herself to the point of not being able to breathe. Her tears fell onto Liang Shi's cheek.

Warm.

Xu Qingzhu gasped heavily, catching her breath.

Only after she had recovered did she say in a hoarse voice: "My heat period is over."

Liang Shi's hand unconsciously squeezed, but it caused Xu Qingzhu to cry out in pain. She then lightly patted Liang Shi's shoulder.

Only then did Liang Shi pull her hand out, taking the opportunity to pull her sweater back down.

"Mm." Liang Shi said.

The corners of Xu Qingzhu's eyes were tinged red, but her gaze was clear. "Omegas don't only get intimate with people during their heat period."

Liang Shi looked at her at eye level, their gazes meeting.

Xu Qingzhu grabbed her collar and kissed the corner of her mouth again.

"I get intimate with you because I like you." Xu Qingzhu said: "Not because you're my wife."

"Actually, I'm in a lot of pain." Xu Qingzhu's voice became slightly choked as she spoke. "It hurts up here, and it hurts down there too. But I want to do it with you... because it's with you, not because I like doing it."

She raised her hand to wipe away the smudged lipstick from the corner of Liang Shi's mouth.

After saying all this, looking at Liang Shi's somewhat dazed expression, her heart felt like it was blocked by a large stone.

She couldn't say anything more.

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"Forget it." Xu Qingzhu climbed off her, picked up her coat from the side, and pushed open the car door to get out.

But just as she was about to leave, Liang Shi grabbed her arm and pulled her back. The car door slammed shut again with a bang.

This time, she was pulled directly into Liang Shi's embrace.

Xu Qingzhu even lost her balance and fell entirely onto Liang Shi, hitting her quite hard.

Liang Shi let out a muffled grunt, but still lowered her head to look at Xu Qingzhu.

Those light brown pupils were like glass marbles—impossibly beautiful.

Xu Qingzhu's eyes were misty with moisture.

"What?" Xu Qingzhu said: "I'm going to work."

"Wait." Liang Shi's hand gripped her wrist tightly, refusing to let go. "Let me think for a moment."

"Then you think first." Xu Qingzhu tried to break free from her grip. "We can talk about it tonight."

"No, it has to be now." Liang Shi stared at her, her fingertips brushing over her lower eyelid. "If I don't explain things clearly to you, you're going to cry again."

Xu Qingzhu was momentarily stunned, then stubbornly turned her face away. "No I won't."

"Delicate little thing."¹ Liang Shi smiled helplessly: "I know you."

"Don't think you understand me so well." Xu Qingzhu said: "You can't even figure things out as a bystander. How could you possibly understand what I'm saying in such a short time?"

Liang Shi pressed her lips together: "What do you mean?"

"Liang Wanwan likes Chen Mian. Did you notice?" Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi: "..."

"No." Liang Shi said, then paused. "Chen Mian is Wanwan's idol. Isn't it normal for her to like Chen Mian?"

"Not that kind of like." Xu Qingzhu said: "It's another kind."

Liang Shi: "..."

"Isn't there only one kind of like?" Liang Shi asked back.

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

"This is why I said I can't explain it to you clearly." Xu Qingzhu said: "You don't need to understand. I'll adjust on my own."

When Xu Qingzhu said the second half of that sentence, there was an indescribable grievance in her voice, but this was already her trying her best to regulate her emotions.

It was still somewhat difficult to control.

If love could be controlled, why would there be so many lovesick fools in this world?

Emotions are inherently complex.

So complex that Xu Qingzhu had spent a long time studying them, yet had only learned the bare basics.

She had also spent a long time troubled by it all, but she always digested it silently on her own.

Telling herself, it's fine—liking someone doesn't mean you need them to like you back.

—Isn't liking someone just being good to them regardless of everything else? Why need any response?

—Liang Shi is already so busy and tired. Don't bother her with these trivial matters.

—Always asking whether she loves me or not seems too clingy. If I'm too clingy, Liang Shi won't like me either.

She had comforted herself with these words countless times, but she was really just too greedy.

She thought she could always keep the promise she made to Liang Shi by the sea—you can kiss me, no need to take responsibility.

Xu Qingzhu had always believed that feelings were her own affair. It was: I like you, you don't need to respond, I'll take responsibility for my own feelings.

Whether or not you like me cannot affect my liking you.

Even if you really don't like me, even if you have many concerns, as long as you're moved in this moment, I can let you irresponsibly enjoy this moment's pleasure.

Because—I love you.

But Liang Shi was too wonderful.

So wonderful that she wanted to possess her completely, wanted her to smile only at her, wanted her to show that indulgent smile only to her, wanted her to be moved only when she was with her.

Xu Qingzhu wanted to be the only one in her world, wanted to be the most special person by her side.

Not simply because she was her wife, so she was gentle to her, so she was good to her.

Liang Shi was good to everyone.

Xu Qingzhu wasn't special.

Just now, Xu Qingzhu had wanted to get an answer. But looking at Liang Shi's troubled expression, Xu Qingzhu felt that the answer wasn't so important anymore.

As long as Liang Shi stayed by her side, that was enough.

She didn't want to see that pained expression on Liang Shi's face.

Xu Qingzhu convinced herself that she could digest this alone.

She wanted to give Liang Shi so much love, wanted to make up for all the love she had never received.

But unknowingly, she had presented Liang Shi with a difficult problem.

Footnotes:

¹ **Delicate little thing** (嬌氣包): Literally "delicate/spoiled bundle," this is an affectionate term used to describe someone who is sensitive, easily upset, or needs to be pampered. It's often used endearingly between lovers to tease someone for being emotionally sensitive or needing extra care.

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Xu Qingzhu's heart ached, twisting painfully. She lowered her eyes. "It's really nothing. Don't overthink it. Just now, I..."

She paused, then pretended to comfort Liang Shi nonchalantly: "I was just teasing you."

Liang Shi was stunned. "What do you mean?"

"It's just..." Xu Qingzhu said as she leaned in to kiss her. "A joke, to lighten the mood."

This was utterly ridiculous.

Let alone Liang Shi—even Xu Qingzhu herself didn't believe it.

But Xu Qingzhu's own mood was already bad enough.

These past few days, she couldn't help but think about these things, falling into a strange mental loop.

At her worst moments, she even thought—maybe they should just divorce.

When she got married back then, it was to that person, not the current Liang Shi.

But once they divorced, could they get married again?

Would the current Liang Shi still be with her?

This was a question she almost didn't dare to think about, because she had even secretly shed tears over it in her office.

Although she categorized these feelings as: post-heat period sensitivity.

She had also looked up information online, which said that Omegas would feel this kind of insecurity after being marked by an Alpha, worrying that the Alpha might leave at any time.

After all, in the relationship between an Alpha and an Omega, it was the Omega who was most affected.

Whether physically or psychologically, Omegas were more dependent on Alphas. The internet said this was the influence of pheromones.

But Xu Qingzhu felt that even without pheromones, she would still be deeply affected by this.

Pheromones were just an external aid—she was psychologically, truly dependent on Liang Shi.

This dependence wasn't about needing Liang Shi to help her do things, but about fearing that she would leave.

Just like before, falling into a coma.

Although she had woken up now and had promised she wouldn't disappear like last time again.

But was what she said definitely true?

Her last disappearance was something even she herself hadn't anticipated.

For something that even Liang Shi herself didn't know about, how credible could her promise be?

Liang Shi was too calm. Although she would blush when teased in daily life, she would also blush when seeing a couple on the street doing something slightly intimate.

That was just a characteristic of hers.

It couldn't be taken as proof that she loved her.

Sometimes Xu Qingzhu felt she was too clever, too fond of observing and pursuing details.

She could clearly judge many things, like knowing that Liang Shi needed to obtain something from her.

After becoming more familiar with Liang Shi, she knew she wasn't someone with broad or refined hobbies.

Even if she was an ordinary person, Xu Qingzhu still liked her.

Yet she would take Xu Qingzhu to concerts.

That pianist, though internationally renowned, didn't have the best reputation. Xu Qingzhu actually didn't like him that much, but since Liang Shi asked, she said she did.

Then there was that time making ceramics.

Liang Shi was very serious about that kind of handicraft, but she herself wasn't particularly interested—she just did it as if completing a task.

And then there was that time playing escape room.

Xu Qingzhu was genuinely anxious. She wished she could just tell Liang Shi directly: "Whatever tasks you have to complete, tell me. I'll help you complete all of them."

But she didn't dare. She was afraid Liang Shi would retreat, afraid she would be scared.

So she could only probe gently, getting the answers she wanted through repeated probing.

Whatever Liang Shi proposed, Xu Qingzhu would never refuse.

It was all because of this.

Xu Qingzhu felt she could deceive herself for a lifetime, as long as Liang Shi remained the current Liang Shi.

Her jiejie.

She could do it.

But lately, her emotions had been increasingly on the verge of losing control. She would inexplicably think about many questions, thinking until she couldn't sleep, thinking until tears flowed. Then in the middle of the night, she would stir Liang Shi's emotions and do those things with her to calm herself down.

It was probably after going through the heat period that she had become more and more anxious about gains and losses.

One day she even had a nightmare. When she woke up and felt the empty space beside her, she was so scared she trembled. She hurriedly got up to look, but her legs buckled and she collapsed to her knees on the ground.

That day, Liang Shi had just gotten up to use the bathroom.

When Liang Shi came back and saw her collapsed on the ground, she was startled. She immediately went forward to help her up, asking what was wrong.

Only then did Xu Qingzhu belatedly realize her behavior was too absurd. She didn't dare say it was because she was afraid Liang Shi had disappeared, afraid she would feel guilty about being in a coma for so long.

So Xu Qingzhu lied: "I slept too long. My legs went numb."

Liang Shi even laughed at her: "That's something you don't see every day."¹

That day, they were reckless again.

From midnight until dawn, Xu Qingzhu's voice was hoarse from crying.

All the emotions she didn't dare to show in front of Liang Shi were released through intimacy.

At this moment, Xu Qingzhu didn't dare to stay in this space any longer. She was afraid she would start crying.

She forcefully broke free from Liang Shi's hand. "I really do have things to do. I need to go first."

But Liang Shi held onto her, pulling her into her embrace.

After a moment, Liang Shi said: "Xu Qingzhu, there won't be anyone else."

Liang Shi's voice was somewhat halting. In this still somewhat proper situation and setting, it was rather difficult to say.

But she still said firmly: "Only you."

—You are the only one, and you are special.

¹ **"That's something you don't see every day"** (活久見): A Chinese internet slang phrase that literally means "live long enough and you'll see anything." It's used to express surprise at something unusual or unexpected, similar to saying "well, that's a first" or "now I've seen everything."